

Train-the- Trainer Toolkit

Restorative Justice & Healing-Centered Organizing — teach these frameworks in your own chapter, coalition, or org.

How to Use This Toolkit

This toolkit exists so that one trained facilitator can teach restorative, healing-centered practices to their own chapter, coalition, or partner org — without waiting on a centralized IRN training calendar. It's built around four practitioner frameworks (Sections A–D) and a delivery guide for teaching them to others (Section E).

WHO THIS IS FOR

Chapter leads, organizers, and peer facilitators who have either completed Radiant Threshold's Know Your Rights / organizer training track, or who carry equivalent lived/organizing experience and want a structured way to pass it on.

WHAT THIS TOOLKIT IS NOT

SCOPE BOUNDARY: This is a practical organizing and facilitation resource — not a clinical mediation credential, not legal advice, and not a substitute for trained victim-offender mediators in cases involving serious physical harm, intimate partner violence, child safety, or anything where a participant's immediate safety is in question. Section C names these boundaries explicitly. When in doubt, refer out — to a certified RJ practitioner, a clinician, or your chapter's safety lead — rather than facilitate alone.

HOW THE SECTIONS BUILD

SECTION	COVERS	USE IT WHEN
A — RJ Fundamentals	What restorative justice is, and why IRN uses it instead of punitive/carceral responses	Orienting new organizers or a chapter encountering RJ for the first time
B — Circle Facilitation	Structure, roles, and scripts for running a restorative circle	Any recurring chapter practice — check-ins, planning, post-action debriefs
C — Responding to Harm	A step-by-step framework for when harm happens inside organizing spaces	Internal conflict, a campaign rupture, a coalition conflict
D — Reentry & Abolition-Focused RJ	Bringing returning citizens back into movement work using RJ principles	Reentry support programming, chapter onboarding for formerly incarcerated members
E — Train-the-Trainer Guide	How to actually teach A–D to your own org	Planning a workshop, becoming a certified local facilitator

RJ Fundamentals

What Restorative Justice Is

Restorative justice (RJ) is a framework for responding to harm that centers repair, accountability, and relationship — instead of punishment alone. Where a punitive response asks *"what rule was broken, and what punishment fits?"*, a restorative response asks three different questions:

- **Who was harmed, and what do they need?**
- **Who is responsible, and what do they need to do to make it right?**
- **Whose obligation is it to address the harm, and what process gets everyone there together?**

RJ as an Alternative to Carceral Responses

For an organization built on prison and police abolition, this isn't a side practice — it's consistency. An org that calls for restorative, non-carceral responses to harm in the outside world and then defaults to punitive, exclusionary, or police-involved responses to harm *inside its own chapters* is working against itself. RJ is how IRN practices internally what it organizes for externally.

Core principle: Accountability without exile. A restorative response asks someone to repair harm and stay in right relationship with the community — not to disappear from it. Removal/exclusion is still sometimes the right call (see Section C), but it's a last resort, not a default.

The Four Pillars

PILLAR	IN PRACTICE
Repair	Centers what the harmed party needs to feel made whole — not just what the responsible party "deserves"
Accountability	The responsible party names the harm in their own words and takes concrete action — not just an apology
Relationship	Treats the people involved as still connected — to each other, to the chapter, to the work
Community Involvement	Harm rarely affects only two people; the process should include who else was impacted

A Note on Where This Comes From

RJ is a long-established field — university centers, federally funded research, and practitioner networks have been refining circle process and harm-response frameworks for decades. This toolkit adapts that field's core practices for movement and organizing contexts specifically; it doesn't claim to invent RJ. Appendix 2 lists where to go for deeper, certification-track training.

Circle Facilitation Basics

The circle is RJ's core format: a group sits facing each other (not in rows), a talking piece moves around the circle so only one person speaks at a time, and a facilitator holds — not controls — the space.

Circle Structure

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	APPROX. TIME
Opening	Facilitator grounds the group, states purpose, sets the talking piece in motion	5–10 min
Check-in round	Everyone speaks once — low-stakes prompt, builds presence	10–15 min
Core round(s)	The actual topic — planning, debrief, or harm response (see Section C)	varies
Closing round	Everyone speaks once more — what they're taking with them	10 min

THE FACILITATOR'S ROLE

- Hold the structure (talking piece order, time), not the content — the circle's voices are the content
- Never speak twice as much as anyone else in the circle
- Name the ground rules out loud, every time, even with a familiar group
- Track who's been quiet — silence isn't always consent, sometimes it's discomfort

GROUND RULES TO STATE EVERY TIME

- Only the person holding the talking piece speaks
- You can pass — passing is always okay
- What's said in circle stays in circle, unless someone discloses an immediate safety risk
- Speak from your own experience ("I" statements), not on behalf of others

READY-TO-USE SCRIPT: OPENING A CIRCLE

```
FACILITATOR OPENS –

"We're going to take a few minutes to ground before we start. [Brief breathing/grounding moment, 30–60 seconds.]

This is a circle, which means everyone's voice carries equal weight today – including mine. The talking piece will move around the circle in order. While someone's holding it, the rest of us are listening, not responding, not interrupting. You can always pass.

What's shared here stays here, with one exception: if I hear something that tells me someone isn't safe, I have to follow up on that outside of this circle, and I'll tell you that's what I'm doing.

I'll start the talking piece moving with [check-in prompt]."
```

READY-TO-USE SCRIPT: CLOSING A CIRCLE

```
FACILITATOR CLOSES –

"We're going to close the way we opened – one round, talking piece only, no responses. [Closing prompt: "One word for how you're leaving" / "One thing you're taking with you."]

Thank you for showing up fully for this. [Name any concrete next steps/follow-ups before ending.]"
```

COMMON PITFALLS

- **Letting the circle become a debate.** If cross-talk starts, gently restate: "talking piece only" — don't let it slide because the conversation feels productive.

- **Skipping ground rules with a "regular" group.** Regulars need the reminder as much as newcomers; it resets the container.

- **Facilitator fills silence.** A pause after someone passes is not a problem to solve. Let it sit.

Responding to Harm in Organizing Spaces

This is the framework for when harm happens inside your own chapter, campaign, or coalition — a broken commitment, a boundary violation, a public conflict that damaged trust.

READ THIS BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE IN SECTION C: This framework is for interpersonal organizing conflict — missed accountability, boundary violations, trust breaches, public disputes. It is not a framework for intimate partner violence, sexual assault, child safety concerns, or any situation involving an ongoing physical safety risk. Those situations need a trained clinician, a certified RJ practitioner with that specialization, or — depending on what the harmed party wants — outside intervention. Facilitating those situations with this toolkit alone is outside its scope and could cause real harm. Know the line, and refer out when you hit it.

The Five-Step Framework

STEP	WHAT IT ASKS
1. Safety First	Is everyone physically and emotionally safe right now? If no, that's the only thing to address before anything else.
2. Acknowledge	Name that harm happened, without assigning the full story yet. "Something happened here that needs attention" is enough to start.
3. Process	Separately, then together: what happened, from each person's own account. The harmed party speaks first when ready.
4. Repair	What does the harmed party need to feel made whole? What is the responsible party willing and able to do?
5. Reintegrate (or not)	Decide together what ongoing relationship looks like — full reintegration, a changed role, or in some cases, that this person steps back from the space. All three can be a restorative outcome.

BEFORE YOU CONVENE ANYONE

- ☐ Talked to the harmed party first, privately — do they want this process at all?
- ☐ Confirmed there's no immediate safety risk that changes the approach
- ☐ Identified whether this needs a circle, a smaller meeting, or one-on-one conversations first
- ☐ Have a co-facilitator if the harm involves someone you're personally close to

SAMPLE INTAKE QUESTIONS (ASK THE HARMED PARTY FIRST, PRIVATELY)

- "What happened, in your own words?"
- "What do you need right now — to be heard, for something to change, distance, something else?"
- "Is there anyone else who was affected by this that should be part of the conversation?"
- "What would it look like for this to feel resolved to you?"

A Note on Power

Restorative process can be misused to pressure a harmed party into "moving on" faster than they're ready to, especially when the responsible party holds more power, status, or seniority in the chapter. Watch for this. The harmed party's timeline governs the process — not the chapter's discomfort with unresolved tension.

Reentry & Abolition-Focused RJ

RJ shows up at a specific, high-stakes moment in movement work: when someone returning from incarceration steps back into a chapter, a campaign, or organizing life. This section is about making that re-entry restorative rather than something the returning member has to navigate alone.

What Makes Reentry-Focused RJ Different

This isn't about repairing a specific harm between two people — it's about repairing a person's relationship to *collective life* after a system designed to sever it. The same four pillars from Section A apply, but the "harm" being addressed is structural (incarceration, isolation, loss of standing) as much as interpersonal.

PRACTICAL ONBOARDING FRAMEWORK

PHASE	WHAT THE CHAPTER DOES
Before release / early contact	Identify a single point-of-contact in the chapter so the returning member isn't navigating multiple relationships cold
First 30 days	Low-stakes reintegration — check-ins, circle participation, no expectation of immediate "full" organizing role
Role re-entry	Returning member chooses their pace back into responsibility; chapter doesn't default to either over-protecting or over-loading them
Ongoing	Treat record/history as context, not a permanent label — this is the abolitionist throughline: people are not the worst thing that happened to them or the system's record of them

Coordination note: If your chapter is doing reentry support work alongside benefits navigation, housing, or clinical/peer support partners, RJ principles work alongside those — not instead of them. This section covers the relational/organizing piece; pair it with your chapter's existing reentry resource partners for the material needs (housing, benefits, healthcare access).

Abolition-Focused RJ in Campaign Work

When IRN organizes against carceral responses externally (police presence, prosecutorial overreach, prison expansion), reentry-focused RJ internally is the proof of concept — it's how a chapter demonstrates the alternative it's organizing for, in how it treats its own returning members.

Train-the-Trainer Guide

This is the part that makes you a multiplier, not a bottleneck — how to actually teach Sections A–D to your own chapter or org.

90-Minute Workshop Session Plan

TIME	SEGMENT	WHAT TO DO
0:00–0:10	Opening circle	Use the Section B opening script. This isn't a warm-up — it's modeling the practice you're about to teach.
0:10–0:30	RJ Fundamentals (Section A)	Present the four pillars. Ask the group: where have you already seen punitive vs. restorative responses play out in our chapter?
0:30–0:55	Circle practice (Section B)	Run a real, low-stakes circle live — let participants experience structure, not just hear about it
0:55–1:15	Harm-response walkthrough (Section C)	Walk through the five-step framework using a hypothetical, low-stakes scenario — never a real, unresolved chapter conflict in a training setting
1:15–1:25	Reentry framing (Section D)	Shorter pass — connect to any chapter members currently in or supporting reentry
1:25–1:30	Closing circle	Use the Section B closing script

MATERIALS CHECKLIST

- ☐ A talking piece (any object the group agrees on — doesn't need to be special)
- ☐ Printed or screen copies of Sections A–C for participants
- ☐ A private space — circles do not work well in a space people are walking through
- ☐ A co-facilitator, especially for your first few sessions

ADAPTING BY CHAPTER CONTEXT

This toolkit is written to travel between IRN's Baltimore base and the 757/Hampton Roads operations, and beyond — the frameworks don't change, but your opening prompts and hypothetical scenarios in Section C practice should. Pull examples from your chapter's actual campaign work (without using real unresolved conflicts), not generic ones.

Becoming a Certified Local Facilitator

1. Complete Radiant Threshold's Know Your Rights track and attend at least one circle led by an experienced facilitator
2. Co-facilitate two sessions with an experienced facilitator before leading solo
3. Lead a full 90-minute session in your own chapter, with feedback from a co-facilitator or chapter lead
4. Once consistent, you're a chapter-certified Train-the-Trainer facilitator — able to onboard the next person

The multiplier goal: Every certified local facilitator should aim to train at least one more person within their first six months. That's how this scales past a single national training calendar.

Radiant Threshold — Train-the-Trainer Toolkit

7

Quick-Reference Scripts & Checklists

CIRCLE OPENING (SHORT FORM)

"This is a circle – talking piece only, you can always pass, what's said here stays here unless someone's safety is at risk. Starting with *[prompt]*."

CIRCLE CLOSING (SHORT FORM)

"Closing round, talking piece only, no responses: *[prompt]*. Thank you for showing up fully."

HARM-RESPONSE PRE-CHECK (RUN THROUGH BEFORE CONVENING ANYONE)

- ☐ Is everyone physically safe right now?
- ☐ Have I spoken to the harmed party privately first?
- ☐ Does this fall outside this toolkit's scope (IPV, assault, child safety, ongoing danger)? If yes — refer out, stop here.
- ☐ Do I need a co-facilitator for this one?
- ☐ Has the harmed party agreed to the format (circle vs. smaller meeting vs. 1:1s first)?

FIVE-STEP HARM RESPONSE – ONE-PAGE VERSION

#	STEP	ONE-LINE REMINDER
1	Safety First	Nothing else matters until this is true
2	Acknowledge	Name that harm happened — don't assign the full story yet
3	Process	Each account, harmed party first
4	Repair	What's needed vs. what's offered
5	Reintegrate (or not)	All three outcomes can be restorative

Field Resources & Further Training

For complex cases, certification-track training, or deeper grounding in the field this toolkit draws from, these established programs offer dedicated RJ training (independent of IRN — not formal partners, just where the broader field trains):

PROGRAM	FOCUS
National Center on Restorative Justice (NCORJ)	Federally funded; criminal legal system, prisons, reentry, policy. Many free public resources.
IIRP Graduate School	World leader in RJ training; certificates and Training-of-Trainers programs
Suffolk University Center for Restorative Justice	Year-long professional certificate; practitioner leadership focus
University of San Diego Center for Restorative Justice	Certificates, online modules, circle-keeping/facilitation training
National Association of Community and Restorative Justice (NACRJ)	National practitioner network and conference

If you're facilitating a case that needs more than this toolkit covers — escalate to one of the above, or to a clinician/certified mediator, rather than stretching this framework past its scope.

Questions or want to get certified?

Reach your chapter lead, or IRN directly: IRNVP@pm.me